

**SM: You've spoken against the woke culture. You like to provoke Big Tech, don't you?**

**A:** I stand for what I believe in. I started as an entrepreneur, fought Uber, came up on top. Then built Ola Electric when everybody said that Ola doesn't know anything about manufacturing and India doesn't have an EV market. And look at where we are now... So, in a way, if the founding principle of a business is right, and if your intentions are right, you will find your way. And for me and Ola, our focus is always to leverage this India moment. We are at the most exciting time of our lives... where India is growing, [and] the future is going to be built by Indians.

Specifically on the woke thing, Big Tech and digital tech especially is not just about tech and economic productivity; it's also about a certain cultural appropriation of a civilisation. Today, because we use global platforms like Facebook, Snapchat or Instagram, their debates are increasingly [becoming] our debates... Digital tech is also about conserving and promoting your own culture. And culture is not anything political. It's how we live every day. What happens in woke culture is, if you go to LinkedIn, it'll force you to choose your pronoun... our culture traditionally has had a very broad acceptance for all people... This is the western debate that is coming into India through these platforms.

**SIDDHARTH ZARABI,**  
**MANAGING EDITOR,**

**BTTV: What are your thoughts on AI and data protection and protecting the core rights of Indians in the AI era?**

**A:** If you see the current direction of the AI world, every Big Tech company is playing God... they will decide what is right and wrong. In my view, that right is only with the law of the land, and the law of the land should be supreme and applicable to whichever AI model, social media company, and digital platform is running in that country. And even more so for a complex country like India, where some of these nuances are very important to protect according to the law... We have to make sure social media AI algorithms are fully subservient to the law and Parliament... Now that will need some policy, global leadership, [and] thought leadership from the Indian government and

the Indian tech ecosystem... India through its DPI movement—where digital platforms are for social good, beyond just capitalistic good—can amplify this. But it will need a lot of work.

On data protection, I believe one of India's core strengths is our population scale... 20% of the world lives in India; we're also younger. We generate more per capita data than the average westerner or Japanese. This data scale is our strength, and we need to bring strong policy and implementation of policy on data sovereignty, data residency, data management, data decision-making... The whole stack of data management needs to be—through policy and implementation—brought into India.

**SM: You've disrupted the space with the Ola Electric listing and the EV bike's pricing...**

**A:** You have to disrupt to create something new... With Ola Electric, in three years, we've gone from zero sales to listing the company with \$7-8 billion in market cap... It's because the Indian consumer was

ready for a great product at the right price point...

The next EV frontier in India is going to be motorbikes... [they] make up about two-thirds of the two-wheeler market... We have, in the last three years, built a lot of our supply chain [and] manufacturing technology for scooters. And all of that scale nicely into the motorbike. The 4680 [or

Bharat] cell, for example, is common in the scooter, motorbike, [and] in any other future [vehicle]. A lot of this cost efficiency from the supply chain easily scales into motorbikes. And people should be aware by now how I price my products.

**SM: What are the kind of volumes you are looking at?**

**A:** Customers didn't know about EVs three years ago; now everyone knows about EVs. So, customer education is going to be much faster... People want to see electric motorbikes. They've understood the proposition of electric, that it's cheaper to operate, and now the upfront cost is also equal to an ICE vehicle. People are more ready and willing to adopt [EVs]; we are going to build on top of that.

**“The global tech industry is a \$30-trillion industry. India has been a big beneficiary with the IT services boom. [But] the market cap of IT services is \$300 billion, or just 1% of the global tech industry”**